



GPay under scrutiny

The Competition Commission is looking into allegations that Google is unfairly promoting GPay. <https://dgit.in/jun20-104>



Spotify lifts library limits

Add as many songs as you want to your libraries, but download restrictions remain intact. <https://dgit.in/jun20-105>

REAL LIFE DIFFERS FROM SIMULATED TEST ENVIRONMENTS

Firstly, the IP rating is not cumulative. So, smartphones as well as other devices, are not required to pass every single test that leads up to the highest level of rating. While some companies do test for varying degrees of protection, achieving a high rating definitely does not require it. So, to achieve an IP67 rating, smartphones need to only ensure that they can survive submersion for up to 1 meter for a period of 30 minutes. They are usually not certified for durability against, say, powerful water jets. This kind of stress often requires a different grade of device sturdiness than what is needed for just submerging a device underwater. Sometimes, a phone is rated for both spray and immersion, and manufacturers will grant it two IP ratings. An example is Sony's recent flagship, the Xperia 1 II, which features both IP65 and IP68 rating. This means it can not only weather water jets but also submersion. However, this is uncommon



The Sony Xperia 1 II has two IP ratings

since most phones only come sporting one IP rating, so it is tough to say whether the manufacturers have tested it for other variables. Not so assuring now, is it?

Secondly, IP rating scores are also derived under certain simulated conditions. For water resistance, the tests are usually done with freshwater. How-



Visual from the Samsung Galaxy S8 launch event which shows the phone being used in a pool

ever, sea water (salt water) and chlorine in pools affect phones very differently. They can cause near-instant corrosion in the insides of your phone. This process is sped up even further if your phone is not spanking new. Daily usage causes a phone to lose its integrity, bit by bit, especially if you are a frequent dropper. Even temperature fluctuations, such as being in the outdoors heat and then suddenly going into an AC-cooled room can speed the ageing process of your phone. When your phone ages, even by a bit, the adhesive which binds the glass and metal exterior and interior of your phone gets compromised. This directly impacts the IP rating and how well a smartphone can stand up against dust and water. This is usually why almost no smartphone manufacturer provides warranty against the dreaded water damage. Water kills phones, it is as simple as that. Over time your smartphone, even if it is IP69 rated, will lose its IP rating due to loss of structural integrity and if you're not careful, it will become a victim to water damage. So, it is integral that smartphone manufacturers try to educate their users about these possibilities. Unfortunately, that is usually not the case.

The Australian Competition & Consumer Commission (ACCC) took Samsung Australia to court over the S10 lineup's water-resistance capabilities for "false, misleading and deceptive representations in advertising the

water resistance of various 'Galaxy' branded mobile phones". They believe that Samsung has repeatedly been misleading users with their advertisements since 2016 that often show people using these phones in pools and underwater in the ocean. The funny part is that Samsung mentions on their website that the S10 comes with IP68 water resistance and it is not advised for "pool and beach use". Yet we see ads like those from the company, which blatantly mislead consumers for economic gain.

So, is any smartphone on the market waterproof? No. Is any phone truly water-resistant? Yes, but only under optimal conditions and certainly not when it has a few bumps, bruises and especially cracks! Since water damage is not covered under warranty, it is integral that you take the necessary precautions to keep your device as dry as possible. Manufacturers will always know if a phone is malfunctioning due to water damage since they have little 'water contact indicator tapes' that turn pink or red when they come in contact with water. Just like those litmus papers we used for experiments in school. So, to reiterate, keep your phone dry and rely on the IP rating only for the occasional accident or two. Don't become one of those cautionary tales everyone tells to warn against the mostly irreparable consequences of water damage. 